UNIV 497: Interdisciplinary Capstone Studio

Fall 2026 | Instructor: Dr. Renata Okafor | Project Brief and Course Policies

1. Course overview

In this capstone, interdisciplinary teams of four to six students partner with a community sponsor to research, design, prototype, and test a solution to a real problem the sponsor faces. You will work the way professional project teams work: you will scope the problem with your sponsor, research the people affected, build and test a prototype, and present a recommendation. No single major is expected to carry the project. Every team needs research, design, technical, writing, and client-management skills, and the grading reflects that.

The semester runs 15 instructional weeks. Week 1 begins Monday, August 24, 2026. Thanksgiving break (November 23 to 29) is not a course week. Week 14 begins Monday, November 30, and Week 15 begins Monday, December 7.

2. Deliverables and due dates

All written deliverables are submitted on the course site by 11:59 pm on the due date unless noted.

Milestone	Deliverable	Week	Due	Weight
M0	Team charter (roles, meeting norms, communication and conflict plan)	2	Fri, Sep 4	5%
M1	Project proposal and scope agreement signed by sponsor	5	Fri, Sep 25	10%
M2	Research and requirements report (minimum five stakeholder interviews, personas, prioritized requirements)	7	Fri, Oct 9	15%
M3	Prototype milestone and sponsor demo (see Section 4)	10	Fri, Oct 30	20%
M4	Usability test report (minimum five test participants)	13	Fri, Nov 20	15%
M5	Final presentation (in class, Dec 8 to 10) and final report	15	Fri, Dec 11	25%
PE	Peer evaluations and individual contribution (submitted twice: with M3 on Fri, Oct 30, and with M5 on Fri, Dec 11)	10, 15	Oct 30; Dec 11	10%

3. Grading summary

Team milestones (M0 through M5) account for 90% of the course grade and are scored as a team. The remaining 10% is individual and is based on peer evaluations, the contribution logs described in Section 5, and instructor observation. A student whose contribution is documented as substantially below the team's may receive an individually adjusted milestone grade. This is rare and is always preceded by a conversation with the instructor.

4. Milestone 3: Prototype and sponsor demo (20%)

Milestone 3 shows that your team can turn its research into something the sponsor can see and react to. The prototype may be coded or built in a design tool (for example, a clickable prototype) as long as a person can complete each core user flow without help. The sponsor demo must take place during Week 10, no later than Thursday, October 29, so that sponsor feedback can be included in the submission.

Component	What earns full credit	Weight
Working prototype	Covers every core user flow listed in your M1 scope agreement. A person outside the team can complete each flow without guidance.	35%
Requirements traceability	A table linking each prototype feature to a requirement from your M2 report, and each high-priority requirement to a feature or a stated reason it was deferred. Requirements the sponsor has raised since M2 must be included.	15%
Accessibility review	A completed WCAG 2.2 AA checklist covering every screen in the prototype, with issues found and how they were addressed or why they were deferred.	15%
Sponsor demo and feedback	The demo took place by Oct 29. Submission includes dated notes of sponsor feedback and the team's response to each point.	15%
Data and privacy plan	One to two pages: what personal data the solution would collect, why each item is needed, where it would be stored, who can see it, and how long it is kept.	10%
Updated project plan	Revised plan for Weeks 11 to 15 with owners and dates for M4 and M5 work, reflecting what the team learned in Weeks 1 to 10.	10%

Required with every milestone submission: a contribution log (see Section 5). A missing log costs five points from the milestone score.

Milestones 4 and 5 (summary)

M4 requires a usability test with at least five participants from the sponsor's actual user group, a findings summary, and the changes made in response. M5 requires a 15-minute final presentation to the class and sponsor, and a final report covering the problem, research, solution, test results, implementation recommendations, and limitations. Detailed rubrics for M4 and M5 will be posted by Week 11.

5. Course policies

Late work. Team milestones lose 10% per calendar day late, up to three days. After three days, the milestone receives no credit unless an extension was approved.

Extensions. Extension requests must reach the instructor at least 48 hours before the deadline and must explain the cause and the proposed new date. Extensions for sponsor scheduling conflicts are considered case by case.

Sponsor communication. Each team names one sponsor liaison, but every team member is responsible for professional conduct with the sponsor. Copy the instructor on all email to the sponsor. Sponsors are volunteers with full-time jobs: **sponsor meetings and demos must be requested from the sponsor at least seven calendar days before the proposed date.**

Contribution log. Each milestone submission includes a short table listing what each team member contributed since the previous milestone. Include work that does not show up in a task tracker, such as design iterations, sponsor communication, editing, and coordination.

Peer evaluation. Each student completes a confidential peer evaluation form, due on the same date as M3 and again with M5. Peer evaluations are read only by the instructor.

Team concerns. Teams are expected to talk through workload and communication problems among themselves first, using the conflict plan in their charter. If that does not resolve a concern, any team member may contact the instructor. Concerns raised by the end of Week 10 (Friday, Oct 30) can be addressed before final grading; concerns raised only at the end of the semester are much harder to act on.

Accommodations. Students with work, caregiving, commuting, or disability-related constraints are encouraged to share what they are comfortable sharing with their team when the charter is written, so the team can plan around it. Students may also speak with the instructor privately.

AI use. AI tools may be used for drafting, analysis, and prototyping. Note in each submission where AI tools were used. Do not enter sponsor data or interview recordings into AI tools without the sponsor's permission.

Appendix A: Sponsor project assignments

Sponsor contacts have agreed to roughly two hours of team contact per month. Please respect their time.

Team	Sponsor	Contact	Project
1	Whitman County Library District	Alan Reyes, Branch Manager	Redesign the teen program sign-up and reminder process.
2	Pullman Regional Transit Riders Group	Grace Kim, Board Chair	Rider feedback collection and reporting for route changes.
3	Palouse Ice Rink Association	Tom Bauer, Operations Lead	Online booking for youth hockey practice ice time.
4	Palouse Harvest Food Share	Dana Whitfield, Volunteer Coordinator	Volunteer shift sign-up and scheduling (details below).
5	Moscow-Pullman Habitat Restoration Network	Leah Ostrander, Program Director	Field data collection tool for native planting surveys.

Team 4 project description

Palouse Harvest Food Share relies on about 140 active volunteers to staff food sorting, distribution days, and deliveries. Volunteers currently sign up through a mix of a paper sheet at the warehouse, a shared online form, and text messages to the volunteer coordinator. Shifts are regularly under-staffed or double-booked, and the coordinator spends several hours a week confirming who is coming.

The sponsor has asked the team to design a solution in which:

• volunteers can see open shifts and sign up from a phone;

• volunteers receive a reminder before each shift; and

• the coordinator can see who is scheduled for each shift and day.

The sponsor has also mentioned interest in a way for volunteers to see a record of their hours. The team should confirm the priority of this and any other requests with the sponsor and document the agreed scope in M1. The solution does not need to be production software; the sponsor's goal is a tested design and a recommendation they can take to a volunteer developer or vendor.